



Morale patch

This aviator patch, from 1964, shows a bird holding a bomb or shell. Fun patches like this one, known as morale patches, were designed by artistic service personnel, who had them made in tailor shops in Saigon.

Phantoms and Thunderchiefs

The US answer to the MiG-21 was the F-4 Phantom, the USAF's most successful interceptor and the Navy's main fleet-defense fighter. It was also a ground attack jet, although the F-105 Thunderchief was the primary plane used in Operation Rolling Thunder. Designed to deliver nuclear weapons into the Soviet Union, the F-105 was also an effective conventional fighter-bomber. Its performance at low altitude made it ideal for going "Downtown," as pilots called the heavily defended airspace around Hanoi.

The principal air-to-air weapon of the F-4 and the F-105 was the AIM-9 Sidewinder infrared-guided or heat-seeking missile. Developed in the 1950s, the sidewinder saw its first extended use in Vietnam.

■ 28 The number of MiGs destroyed by Sidewinder missiles from F-4 Phantoms between 1965 and 1968.

Air duels

North Vietnamese commanders hesitated to risk MiG-21s against the F-4s in air-to-air combat. They preferred to take on the slower Thunderchiefs and would often use ground-control radar guidance to attack the Thunderchiefs from the rear, forcing them to dump their ordnance before reaching their target. Against F-4s, the MiG pilots would delay their attack until late in the bombing run, when the Americans' fuel was low.